

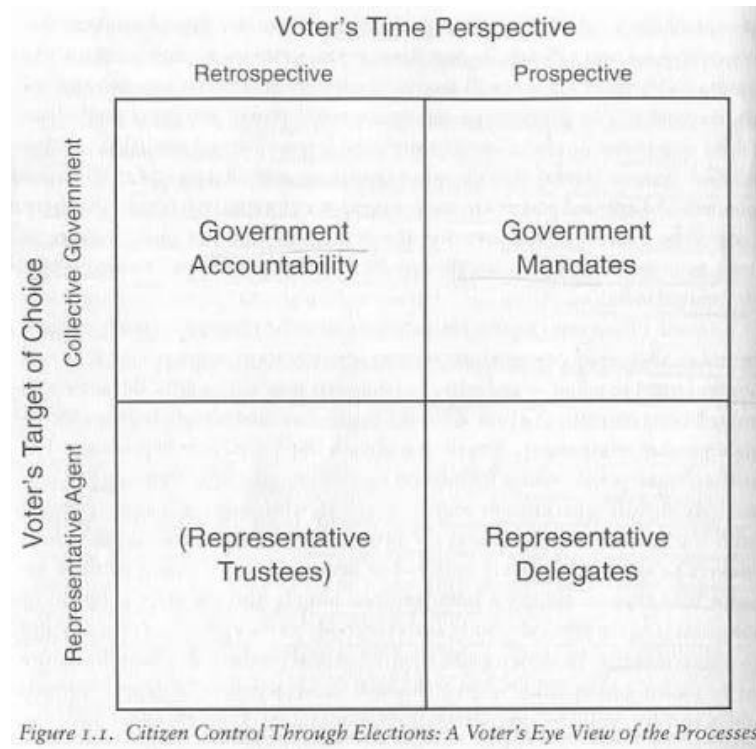
Powell 2000 RG Notes

Powell, G. Bingham Jr. *Elections as Instruments of Democracy: Majoritarian and Proportional Visions*.
New Haven: Yale University Press, 2000.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- Primary distinction between democratic approaches: *control* over policymakers or *influence* over policy. Each corresponds to a certain “grand vision” of electoral accountability:
 - Majoritarian: The majority should have a near-absolute right to rule, and policy should proceed in accordance with the majority’s wishes. Focuses on a relationship of power between voters and their elected officials, whereby voters become “principals” who seek to either reward or control their representatives. Consistent with the “control” narrative. Centralization of power follows from this, and the primary role of the citizen is to enforce consequences during elections.
 - Proportionalism: The will of each group should be reflected in policy in accordance with the relative size of that group. Focuses on a relationship of influence whereby policy is swayed in a degree proportionate to the relative power of that group, subsequently protecting minority welfare at the expense of direct control over the political system. Consistent with the “influence” narrative. Considers elections to be clumsy/noisy signals, and prioritizes universal input without giving an oversized benefit to the majority group
- Voters’ roles can be roughly perceived as either retrospective or prospective. If retrospective, more aligned with majoritarianism: the voter either punishes or rewards incumbents with their vote (or lack thereof), based on the observed quality of their tenure. If prospective, more aligned with proportionalism: the voter seeks credible commitments from candidates and has some expectation of their performance.



3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Making retrospective judgments requires some clarity about specifically *who* made *what* judgments. Requires both some degree of transparency and a sense of consistency from amongst the citizens, who in turn need to accurately perceive the dynamic at hand. This adds an additional dynamic to be considered: clarity of responsibility

4 Connections

-

5 My Critiques

-